

Order Passeriformes continued

Family Turdidae

Thrushes

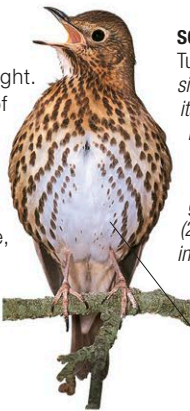
Length 5–12 in (12.5–30 cm)

Species 169



This family, which includes such familiar birds as the American robin and the Eastern bluebird, is widely distributed in Europe, Africa, Asia, Australia, and North America. In fact, thrushes are native to almost all regions, excluding Antarctica and New Zealand. Many, such as the song thrush, are fine singers, the most notable of them all being the nightingale. Thrushes may form a solid pair-bond, singing to proclaim ownership of territory. Species like

the mistle thrush, which nests very early in the year, may be heard singing in the dead of night. Thrushes build cuplike nests of grass and moss, usually in the fork of a bush or tree. Their courtship displays often emphasize their distinctive physical features—for instance, the robin's red breast or the song thrush's speckled breast. During courtship, males of some species, such as the robin, feed the female. However, the female is often solely responsible for nest-building, incubation, and brooding the nestlings. Some species of thrushes, such as the redwing and fieldfare of Scandinavia, are migratory and fly south in winter. Migratory species may form large flocks, but others stick in pairs.



SONG THRUSH

*Turdus philomelos* is a fluent singer—often at dusk—and repeats its phrases 3 or 4 times. Native to Europe, North Africa, and northwest Asia, and introduced in Australia and New Zealand, it is a bird of gardens and woodland. About 9 in (23 cm) long, it feeds on berries, insects, and worms, and is noted for its use of an anvil stone to crack snail shells..

clear speckles on underparts

COMMON BLACKBIRD

Native to Europe, North Africa, and Asia, and introduced in Australia, New Zealand, and South America, *Turdus merula* is 9½–10 in (24–25 cm) long. The male sings melodiously from a prominent perch, particularly in the evenings. Blackbirds are noted for their “chak-chak” calls as they go to roost. They feed on berries, fruit, worms, and insects.

bright orange bill

blue head and back reddish chest



orange eye-ring on male

all-black plumage of male

long tail

Family Sturnidae

Starlings

Length 6½–18 in (16–45 cm)

Species 123



An ability to imitate the sounds they hear is a notable feature of this group of birds, which includes the irrepressible mimics, mynahs. Starlings are found in Africa, Europe, and Asia, but the common starling has been introduced around the world and is now found in 119 nations. These birds have strong legs and bills, and mostly black plumage, often with an iridescent sheen that is particularly noticeable in the African species. Some, such as the long-tailed glossy

starling, have long tails, which can be as much as 14 in (35 cm) in length. Some starlings have areas of bare skin on the face, particularly around the eyes, and the wattled starling has loose folds of skin, known as wattles, on its head. Most of these birds are very much at home on the ground, and several species live among human habitation. Most starlings are residents but some are partial migrants, perhaps moving to find food in winter; the group is by and large omnivorous. Starlings lay 2–6 pale blue-green, often brown-spotted, eggs.

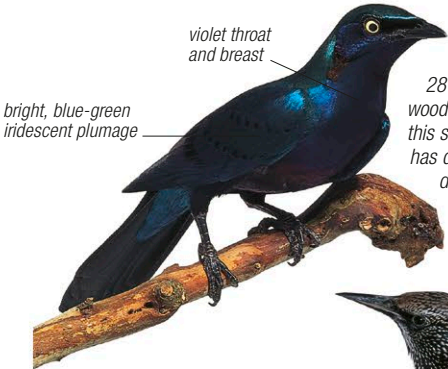


yellow wattle behind eye

glossy black and purple plumage

COMMON HILL MYNAH

Distributed across much of southern and Southeast Asia, *Gracula religiosa* is found in moist forest, where its diverse range of piercing calls are a distinctive feature. It is 11–12 in (28–30 cm) long, and is the typical mynah found in pet shops and aviaries.



violet throat and breast

bright, blue-green iridescent plumage

SPLENDID STARLING

Distributed across much of Africa, in 28 countries, *Lamprolaima splendidus* is a woodland species. Measuring 10½ in (27 cm), this strikingly colored bird is quite shy, and has declined in many places due to large-scale deforestation. Outside of the breeding season, it is known to form flocks.

iridescent sheen of green, blue, or violet



EUROPEAN STARLING

Occurring in 119 countries, *Sturnus vulgaris* is one of the world's most familiar species, having adapted to living alongside humans. This bird—which is 8½ in (21 cm) long—feeds and roosts in large flocks, often perching on building ledges overnight.

Family Cinclidae

Dippers

Length 6–8½ in (15–21 cm)

Species 5



These plump, short-tailed birds, found in Europe, Asia, and North and South America, are rather like aquatic versions of wrens (see p.361). Their tail is often cocked in the same way, and they build a similar domed nest of moss, usually lined with grass and leaves, with an entrance hole at the side. The nest is hidden in a rock crevice, among tree

roots, under a bridge, or behind a waterfall. The female incubates the 3–6 white eggs for about 16 days, and both parents feed the young. As soon as they leave the nest, the young are able to feed underwater. All 5 species of dippers live near fast-flowing hill or mountain streams, catching mayflies and other insects on the bank and shore, and wading into the water to pick insect larvae, snails, and fish eggs from rocks and pebbles. Their enlarged preen gland—10 times bigger than that of other passerines—gives them extra waterproofing.



white throat

plumage repels water

WHITE-THROATED DIPPER

One of the few birds able to “walk” underwater, the chubby, pot-bellied *Cinclus cinclus* is 7–8½ in (18–21 cm) long and has a rasping “strits” call. Found in Europe, North Africa, and northern Asia, it flies low over the water, its wings making a whirring sound as it flies, and nests in crevices and on ledges under bridges.

Family Mimidae

Mockingbirds

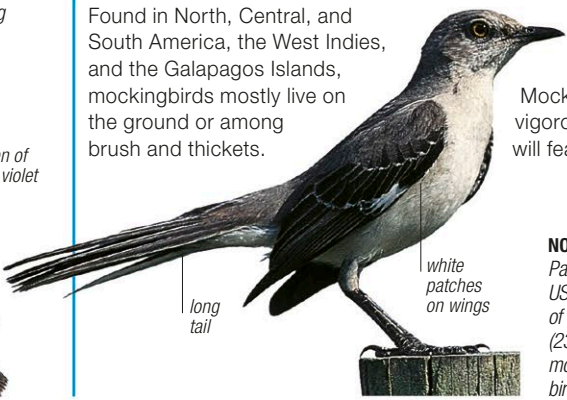
Length 8–13 in (20–33 cm)

Species 34



Found in North, Central, and South America, the West Indies, and the Galapagos Islands, mockingbirds mostly live on the ground or among brush and thickets.

Almost all species are known for their singing and, as the name suggests, some are very good mimics. Many sing at night during the breeding season. Generally long-tailed birds, most mockingbirds are white, gray, or brown; however, 2 species are blue and one is black. They are closely related to thrushes (see p.361), and build similar cup-shaped nests in bushes or trees, where females lay and incubate 2–5 eggs. Mockingbirds are known for their vigorous defence of the nest, and will fearlessly attack intruders.



long tail

white patches on wings

NORTHERN MOCKINGBIRD

Particularly associated with southern USA, *Mimus polyglottos* is the state bird of 5 states in the USA. It is 9–11 in (23–28 cm) long, famous for singing on moonlit nights and incorporating other birds' voices in its song.